by Pakistan meant stopping India from going to war over East Pakistan. Threatening US inaction in case China intervened in a South Asian war was Kissinger's way of telling Mrs Gandhi that Washington would no longer protect India against its northern neighbour – the hope was that this would deter Delhi.

Washington's China opening galvanized Delhi into action. It immediately dusted off a 1969 proposal from Moscow on Asian collective security and turned it into a twenty-five-year treaty of peace, friendship, and cooperation. The treaty included clauses that read like an alliance: both sides were to consult each other in case of a threat to their security and to take appropriate action; and neither side would assist an enemy third party. In the end, the importance of the treaty was probably more symbolic and psychological than material. Given the stopping power of the Himalaya, the logistical challenges Chinese forces would have faced if they intervened in an India–Pakistan war, and Beijing's worries about security along the Sino-Soviet border, China was unlikely to attack India.

However, the treaty did boost Indian morale at a time when the country found itself ranged against China, Pakistan, and the US. It was also pivotal in sealing Delhi's gradual embrace of Moscow that had begun in the late 1950s. Economic relations were quite robust by this time: financial and technical assistance from the Soviets was playing a significant role in developing India's heavy industry sector.[23] More importantly, India's key weapon systems between 1969 and 1978 were imported from the Soviets. These included tanks, submarines, frigates, patrol boats, landing craft, combat aircraft, armoured personnel carriers, helicopters, and surface-to-air missiles (SAMs).[24]

The Soviet intervention in Afghanistan

The polarization between India and the Soviets, on one side, and China and the US, on the other, might have been halted by the warming of ties between Delhi and Washington after Nixon and then Kissinger left the